any links with the Sant, the Janata Party candidate wrote a letter to the Prime Minister in which he said: "Bhindranwale was accompanying you during your election tour of Gurdaspur constituency during the general elections to the seventh Lok Sabha (Parliament) held in January 1980."' [13]

The authors write that the nearest Indira Gandhi ever came to admitting any connection between Bhindranwale and her party was in an interview with the BBC current affairs programme, 'Panorama'. In that interview she was asked whether her party had helped the preacher come to prominence. She replied, 'Certainly not. I did not know him. I never knew him.' But she did say, 'Mr Bhindranwale did go and speak for one of our candidates in the elections. I don't know which candidate it was. I don't know whether he knew him personally or he was annoyed with the local Akalis.' [14]

As a result of the encouragement and support extended by the 1 Akbar Road gang, Bhindranwale emerged from the relative obscurity of being a simple rural Sikh religious preacher to an influential Sikh political force capable of taking on the established Sikh leadership in Punjab. He liked the attention that he and his Taksal were getting from the media, and he enjoyed exposing the vulnerabilities of the senior Akali Dal leadership, which helped him build his own leadership and stature amongst the Sikh masses.

This was the one tangible result that the 1 Akbar Road group had derived from their support to Bhindranwale during Op-1. He had bitten their bait and was now ready for a much bigger role in helping his political mentors achieve their goal. And that occasion was not too far off in the future.